Daan Lindhout

Design & Research Leadership

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SUMMARY

Design and research executive with 25 years shipping products used by 100M+ people across web, native mobile, desktop, and dedicated hardware, and 17 years building and leading UX organizations, including 5 years on executive teams. Built or grew 8 design orgs (5 from zero), scaled Axon's team from 5 to 60+, and built the UX team and discipline at Qualtrics ahead of its $8B acquisition by SAP. Sets cohesive UX strategy for complex, multi-product platforms, partnering with Product and Engineering leaders to raise design's influence on strategy and roadmaps. Builds agentic AI products hands-on in code and teaches graduate AI-native Product Design at Northeastern. Holder of 23 patents across hardware and software.

CORE STRENGTHS

- **AI-Native & Agentic Product Design:** Helped define AI/ML UX patterns across Workday's portfolio and set responsible AI review practices for high-stakes public-safety products at Axon. Also builds agentic AI products hands-on in code.
- **Cohesive UX Strategy Across a Product Suite:** Unified 7 separate Qualtrics products into one XM platform and owned the UX vision for Axon's software, mobile, and hardware ecosystem. Aligned multi-year roadmaps with Product and Engineering VPs and GMs at Workday.
- **Building & Scaling Design Organizations:** Built and scaled UX organizations at Axon, Qualtrics, Socrata, F5, and SumTotal, including growing Axon from 5 to 60+ across Product Design, UX Research, Technical Writing, and Design Ops. Leads Directors, design managers, and Senior Principal ICs, and grows designers at every career level with career ladders and growth frameworks.
- **Design Systems, Consistency & Accessibility:** Established design systems and drove their adoption at SumTotal, F5, Socrata, Qualtrics, and Axon, where the Axon Design System spans software and hardware (80%+ adoption). Owned WCAG accessibility governance at Axon and Socrata and set UX quality benchmarks at Workday.
- **Data-Led Product Culture:** Uses qualitative and quantitative data, from product instrumentation and A/B testing to continuous UX benchmarking, NPS/CSAT, and SUS, to drive product strategy and roadmaps; established UX Research as a discipline at Socrata and Qualtrics.

EXPERIENCE

Founder · **Spoom Design** & **Adjunct Professor** · **Northeastern University** — Jan 2025 – Present

- Designing and building agentic, AI-native products end-to-end in code (Python, React, SwiftUI) with Claude Code, defining the interaction patterns and behaviors for agent-driven experiences
- Built an automated stock and ETF trading platform with a swing-trading scanner that turns live market data into trade signals; now building an investment portfolio rebalancer that automates allocation decisions
- Built consumer apps for very different audiences, including a timing app for teaching and a family legacy app; now building a cat communication app
- Teaching graduate AI-native Product Design: how AI and agentic automation change interaction models, craft, team roles, and workflows

Senior Director of Product Design · **Workday** — Mar 2023 – Feb 2025

- Developed the long-term UX discipline vision and maturity framework for a multi-product enterprise SaaS platform spanning web and native mobile apps; aligned design decisions with business objectives and revenue targets in partnership with GMs and Product and Engineering VPs
- Helped define future AI/ML UX patterns and drove many implementations across the product portfolio
- Established cross-product design reviews and UX quality benchmarks, measured with every product pillar, that raised consistency, usability, and craft
- Led Directors and Senior Principal ICs, and grew designers and researchers at all levels through career ladders and growth frameworks

VP of Product Design, UX Research & Technical Writing · **Axon** — Mar 2018 – Mar 2023

- Built and led a global UX organization, scaling from 5 to 60+ and adding UX Research, Technical Writing, and Design Operations to Product Design; led Directors, design managers, and Senior Principal ICs, and owned the UX budget
- Owned documentation, including help content, UI text and tone, style guides, and API docs

- Owned the end-to-end UX vision across the product ecosystem (Dispatch/911, Records, Digital Evidence Management), native mobile apps, and hardware (body-worn cameras, in-car camera systems, drones, interview rooms, and signal products), designed to work as one system for first responders in time-critical workflows
- Created the Axon Design System, unifying software and hardware patterns and bringing the product family under one brand (80%+ adoption); owned WCAG accessibility governance for public-sector requirements
- Established responsible AI design practices and ethical review processes for AI in high-stakes public-safety contexts
- Partnered with Product, Engineering, and executive leadership to greatly increase design's impact on company strategy, the roadmap, and the products, and ultimately on customers and users; established cross-product design reviews

Head of UX Design & Research · **Qualtrics** Sep 2015 – Mar 2018

- Joined at Series C-stage hypergrowth and built the UX team and discipline from the ground up, reporting to the co-founder and owning the UX budget; grew to 20+ across design, research, and information architecture
- Unified 7 separate products into one Experience Management (XM) platform with a shared IA and interaction model; created the original XM brand concept
- Led self-service subscription onboarding, activation, and blended free-to-paid experiences that drove conversion and revenue
- Work contributed directly to Qualtrics' $8B acquisition by SAP, with design quality cited as a differentiator

Director of Design & Research · **Socrata** 2014 – 2015

- Redesigned the core product around a patented UI paradigm for exploring large, complex datasets, a competitive advantage
- Established UX Research as a discipline within the first year; owned WCAG accessibility governance for government customers

Director of Design & UX · **Moz** 2013 – 2014

- Led the Design and Creative team (UX, IA & Strategy, Creative Direction, Branding, Motion Design, Illustration) across all products, corporate sites, marketing, conferences, and branding, including self-service onboarding, activation, and free-to-paid experiences
- Moz ranked as the #2 marketing tech brand, behind only Google and ahead of HubSpot, Salesforce, Adobe, and Microsoft

UX Manager · **F5 Networks** 2010 – 2013

- Founded F5's first UX team and design discipline, spanning UX Design, UX Research, and Industrial Design; led bladeUX, a patented redesign of the product interface applied across the network and security portfolio, including BIG-IQ, greatly improving how network admins configure, monitor, and troubleshoot infrastructure
- Designed UX hands-on and shipped many hardware and software products, including load balancers, firewalls, and security apps, plus network troubleshooting workflows; won the Five Star Award, F5's highest employee honor

UX Manager · **SumTotal Systems** 2007 – 2010

- Started the UX team and discipline from scratch; shifted company culture to customer-centered; led a team in the US and India

Product Designer · **Microsoft** 2000 – 2007

- Redesigned the Windows Out-of-Box Experience (OOBE), cutting first-run setup from 22 minutes / 50% failure to 2:10 / 0% failure across hundreds of millions of PCs; partnered with Dell and HP
- Designed mice, keyboards, digital pens, webcams, and fingerprint readers, and invented the Tilt Wheel mouse, which out-earned the original optical mouse and won an International Stevie Award
- Led two large-scale innovation projects that set product direction 3–5 years out

VENTURES

Co-Founder, SkillCafe – AI/ML platform matching people to jobs and learning by skills and location (2016 – 2019)

EDUCATION

MSc, Industrial Design Engineering – Delft University of Technology

THOUGHT LEADERSHIP & MENTORING

Regular mentor and reviewer, University of Washington Human Centered Design & Engineering (HCDE) program · Mentor to UX ICs and design leaders, through MentorCruise and directly · Author, UXmatters · Jury member, UX India · Guest, Fail Faster podcast

AWARDS

International Stevie Award, Best New Product (Microsoft Tilt Wheel) · Five Star Employee Award (F5 Networks) · #2 Most Recognized Marketing Tech Brand (Moz) · Power of One Team Award (SumTotal Systems)